

them with straw, or use fiber strawberry mats around the base of plants (see tip box, left).

Rotate your strawberry crops every few years to prevent a buildup of diseases in the soil. Plants should last for about two to three years, their yields gradually decreasing, so plant replacements in a fresh bed, and do not reuse the original plot for strawberries or for raspberries for several years.

HARVESTING AND STORING

Strawberries are relatively quick to ripen and are ready to pick when the fruits have become fully red. They do not store well, however, so be prepared to eat them or use them for cooking as soon as possible after harvesting.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Strawberries are most commonly afflicted by viruses, gray mold, slugs and snails, and birds. Buy plants that are healthy and disease-free, and rotate every few years to reduce the risk of diseases spreading. Do not water the fruits or foliage and keep plants well-ventilated to prevent gray mold. Mulching with straw helps to improve ventilation. Use slug bait to deter slugs and snails, and netting to deter birds.

TIP CONTAINERS

Strawberry plants will grow happily in containers as long as you ensure that their soil is well-drained and that they have enough root space. Give plants full sun, and make sure that containers do not dry out. You can experiment and grow strawberries in unusual recycled containers (see p.15).

- It is fairly common to see strawberries planted in hanging baskets—which has the added advantage of keeping the plants out of the path of slugs and snails.
- Growing bags are useful, since they come preprepared with their own form of “plastic sheeting.”
- Terra-cotta strawberry pots are also commonly used—place a plant in each of the “cups”—these are space-efficient and ornamental.



Move your strawberry pots to give them the best possible conditions: they need protection against late frosts and full sun when fruits are ripening.